

The Mending Map

The five hand stitches that fix anything — every step drawn out

Your grandfather fixed one jacket for fifty years. He was not sentimental — he was capable. Here are the five stitches he used, described step by step, with the right stitch for every repair.

WHAT YOU NEED

- **Needles** — a pack of assorted hand-sewing needles covers most repairs. Sharps (medium, sizes 7–9) for general fabric; Chenille or tapestry needles for heavy denim, canvas, or leather.
 - **Thread** — all-purpose polyester thread for most repairs (strong, doesn't rot). Cotton thread for cotton and linen garments. Heavy-duty or upholstery thread for denim, canvas, and bags.
 - **Thimble** — a metal or leather thimble on your middle finger pushes the needle through thick layers without stabbing yourself. Optional for thin fabric, essential for denim.
 - **Scissors** — small sharp scissors to trim thread. Nail scissors work fine.
 - **That is all** — these four items cost under €5 and fit in a tin smaller than a deck of cards.
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THREADING THE NEEDLE AND STARTING KNOT

- Cut a length of thread 45–60 cm (18–24 inches). Longer threads tangle; shorter threads run out too fast.
 - Lick the end of the thread to flatten the fibers. Push through the needle eye in one motion.
 - Pull thread through until you have a tail 10–15 cm on the short side and the rest on the long working side.
 - **Starting knot** — make a small loop at the end of the long side. Pass the thread end through the loop twice. Pull to form a small, firm knot.
 - **Begin from the inside of the fabric whenever possible** — so the knot is hidden inside the garment where no one sees it.
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STITCH 1 — THE RUNNING STITCH (QUICK BASTING AND GATHERING)

- **Best for** — temporarily holding fabric in place before a more permanent stitch, gathering fabric, or decorative stitching.
 - **How** — push the needle in from below, pull through. Push back down 5–8 mm ahead. Repeat in a straight line.
 - The thread weaves in and out of the fabric at equal intervals, like a dotted line.
 - **Not strong enough** — for permanent seam repairs. Use as a temporary fix only, or for decorative work.
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STITCH 2 — THE BACKSTITCH (STRONGEST SEAM — USE FOR ALL PERMANENT REPAIRS)

- **Best for** — split seams, torn pockets, fixing hems that have come apart, closing holes in garments.
 - **This is the hand-stitch equivalent of a sewing machine stitch** — each loop locks the next.
 - **Step 1** — bring the needle up through the fabric at point A.
 - **Step 2** — push the needle back down at point B, 5 mm behind A (going backward).
 - **Step 3** — bring the needle up at point C, 5 mm ahead of A (going forward).
 - **Step 4** — push back down at A again (meeting the previous stitch end). The stitches overlap on the top surface, forming a solid unbroken line.
 - **Pull firm after each stitch** — not tight enough to pucker the fabric, but firm enough that you feel resistance.
 - **The result** — on the underside, you see overlapping loops. On the top, an unbroken line of stitches. This is what holds.
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STITCH 3 — THE WHIP STITCH (EDGES AND PATCHES)

- **Best for** — joining two edges together (reattaching a patch, closing a torn edge, attaching a new pocket).
 - Align the two edges to be joined, holding them together.
 - Bring the needle up through both layers near the edge. Wrap the thread over the edge and through both layers again 5 mm along.
 - The thread wraps diagonally over the edge with each stitch.
 - **Strong and fast** — the most common stitch for attaching fabric patches to worn elbows or knees.
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STITCH 4 — THE BLANKET STITCH (REINFORCING EDGES)

- **Best for** — finishing raw edges so they do not fray, reinforcing buttonhole edges, decorative edging on wool blankets and heavy fabric.
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- Work along the edge of the fabric. Bring the needle up through the fabric 5 mm in from the edge.
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- Before pulling the thread fully through, pass the needle through the loop of thread that forms near the edge.
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- Pull through. The loop locks against the edge of the fabric, creating an interlocking chain of stitches along the border.
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- The finished edge resembles a series of even Ls along the margin. Each stitch prevents the one before from unraveling.
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STITCH 5 — THE DARNING STITCH (HOLES IN FABRIC AND SOCKS)

- **Best for** — holes in socks, elbows, knees, or any place where fabric has worn through completely.
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- **Darning works by weaving new thread across the hole to create a fabric replacement** — no patch needed.
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- **Step 1** — run parallel rows of running stitches across the hole (both catching the solid fabric on each side), until the hole is covered in vertical threads.
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- **Step 2** — rotate and weave the thread perpendicular to the first rows, passing over and under each vertical thread like a loom.
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- **Tension** — keep each pass loose enough that the finished darn lies flat. Too tight and it will pucker.
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- **When done** — the hole is covered with a woven grid of thread, secured on all sides by the surrounding fabric.
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NEEDLE AND THREAD GUIDE BY FABRIC

- **Cotton (shirts, T-shirts, light trousers)** — size 7–8 Sharp needle, all-purpose cotton or polyester thread.
 - **Denim (jeans, jackets)** — size 18–20 Chenille or heavy needle, heavy-duty polyester thread, thimble required.
 - **Wool (sweaters, coats)** — size 5–6 Sharp needle, wool or polyester thread matched to color.
 - **Leather (belts, bags, shoes)** — glover's needle (triangular tip), heavy waxed linen thread, pliers to pull needle through.
 - **Synthetics (nylon, polyester)** — size 9–11 Sharp needle, polyester thread (cotton shrinks differently from synthetic).
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FINISHING A STITCH

- When you reach the end of the repair, make two small backstitches on top of each other in the same spot.
 - **Pass the needle under the last stitch loop before pulling the thread completely through** — this locks the end.
 - Cut thread leaving 5 mm. The double lock will not unravel.
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KEEP THIS IN MIND

Keep a threaded needle — already threaded, black and white — in a small tin in your bag or drawer. A repair that takes two minutes is only worth doing if you do not have to find the needle first.

Comment WATER tomorrow — Wednesday's guide is the three water purification methods that fit on a card small enough for your wallet.

SOURCES The Reader's Digest Complete Guide to Needlework (Reader's Digest Association, 1979) · Singer Complete Photo Guide to Sewing (Creative Publishing International, 2009) · Threads Magazine — hand stitch reference guides · Traditional tailoring and mending techniques as documented by Royal School of Needlework (UK)